
TRANSITIONS LAB · STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK

The BRW Framework

Bypass, Repurpose, Weaken: a mechanism-based typology of the strategies a niche actor uses to engage an entrenched regime.

A working framework for innovators, funders, and researchers, classifying each strategy by how it acts on a specific lock-in barrier, not by its ambition relative to the regime as a whole.

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STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK

How niche technologies engage an entrenched regime

Every niche technology arrives into a world already run by an incumbent regime. How it engages that regime, barrier by barrier, largely determines whether it succeeds and for whom.

An incumbent regime is an aligned configuration of technologies, infrastructures, institutions, habits, and expectations that resists change. A better product does not overcome it on merit alone. What matters is the mechanism a niche actor uses against each specific lock-in barrier the regime presents.

The BRW framework classifies those mechanisms. Its central move is to classify a strategy by its functional mechanism, what it actually does to a particular barrier, rather than by its ambition relative to the regime as a whole. This shifts the unit of analysis from the niche-regime relationship to the strategy-barrier relationship, which is where strategic choice is actually exercised. A single niche actor routinely deploys different mechanisms against different barriers within the same regime, and a vocabulary that aggregates over those differences hides the logic at the level where it operates.

3

mechanisms: bypass, repurpose, weaken

4

barrier dimensions, plus regime coherence

1

alignment proposition that ties them together

THE CORE IDEA

Classify the mechanism, not the ambition

Existing typologies classify niche strategies by how far they aim to change the regime overall. BRW instead asks, of each strategy: what does it do to this barrier? The answer is always one of three mechanisms, and naming it correctly is the beginning of a diagnosis.

B

MECHANISM · BYPASS

Construct a parallel system that circumvents the regime

Bypass constructs a parallel system that performs the regime's function by other means, circumventing the incumbent rather than confronting or co-opting it. The niche builds an alternative configuration that delivers the same function through a different route, so there is little direct negotiation with incumbent actors.

KEY POINT

How it works

The niche routes around the regime entirely. Where established infrastructure is absent, as in many emerging-market settings, a niche actor can build an alternative system without confronting incumbent assets at all. The mechanism draws on substitution and leapfrogging logic.

Capability it demands

Engineering and capital-deployment capacity: the niche must be able to design and build the parallel system, and to fund it.

Business-model archetype

Platform or vertically integrated models that internalise the parallel-system construction.

Barrier it best matches

Bypass is matched to hard-tractable, high-materiality, high-coordination barriers, constraints that resist discursive intervention and can only be resolved by building an alternative. Charging infrastructure and large-scale financing arrangements are characteristic instances.

Worked example. Pay-as-you-go financing over mobile money bypasses conventional banking infrastructure, extending credit to riders with no formal banking history by building a parallel financial rail rather than reforming the incumbent one.

R

MECHANISM · REPURPOSE

Redirect an existing regime element toward the niche's purpose

Repurpose redirects an existing regime element toward the niche's purpose, reorienting structure rather than replacing or avoiding it. It draws on the institutional logics of layering (adding new elements alongside existing ones) and conversion (redirecting existing arrangements to new ends).

KEY POINT

How it works

The niche threads into the regime and turns part of it to a new use. This reduces the capital a bypass would demand, because the existing structure provides a substrate the niche would otherwise have to build from scratch, but it requires the incumbent's cooperation.

Capability it demands

Relational and integrative capacity: the niche must be able to negotiate productive engagement with incumbent actors and gain access to their assets.

Business-model archetype

Partnership or franchise models that exploit incumbent assets and distribution.

Barrier it best matches

Repurpose is matched to intermediate barriers with mixed materiality and mixed tractability that offer leverageable existing structure, procurement systems, retail networks, grid capacity, financial institutions, that can be redirected rather than rebuilt.

Worked example. Placing charging at retail forecourts and shops riders already visit repurposes existing retail infrastructure; integrating with a near-universal mobile-money network repurposes a payment rail the regime already runs.

W

MECHANISM · WEAKEN

Erode the foundations sustaining incumbent advantage

Weaken erodes the foundations sustaining incumbent advantage through demonstration, advocacy, and discursive contestation. Rather than building an alternative system or co-opting an existing one, the niche works to reduce the legitimacy, perceived performance, or political support of the incumbent.

KEY POINT

How it works

The mechanism operates through the accumulation of small destabilising effects rather than head-on confrontation. It reduces the taken-for-grantedness of the incumbent, correcting misconceptions, demonstrating superior performance, building coalitions, until the regime's hold loosens.

Capability it demands

Communicative and political capacity: the niche must be able to demonstrate, persuade, and build coalitions, and requires less capital than bypass or repurpose.

Business-model archetype

Advocacy, demonstration, or coalition-based models that monetise legitimacy, visibility, and policy influence rather than transactional throughput.

Barrier it best matches

Weaken is matched to soft-tractable, low-materiality barriers, knowledge gaps, misconceptions, habits, that yield to demonstration and persuasion and can be addressed through accumulated small interventions.

Worked example. Visibly demonstrating that electric operation costs less per kilometre, and correcting through repeated proof the belief that electric motorcycles are unreliable, weakens the incumbent's grip on rider preference without building anything or partnering with anyone.

THE THREE MECHANISMS

One picture of bypass, repurpose, and weaken

The three mechanisms differ in how the niche relates to the regime, and they sit at different points on a spectrum of barrier characteristics. Bypass builds a parallel system, repurpose redirects a regime element, weaken erodes the regime's foundations.

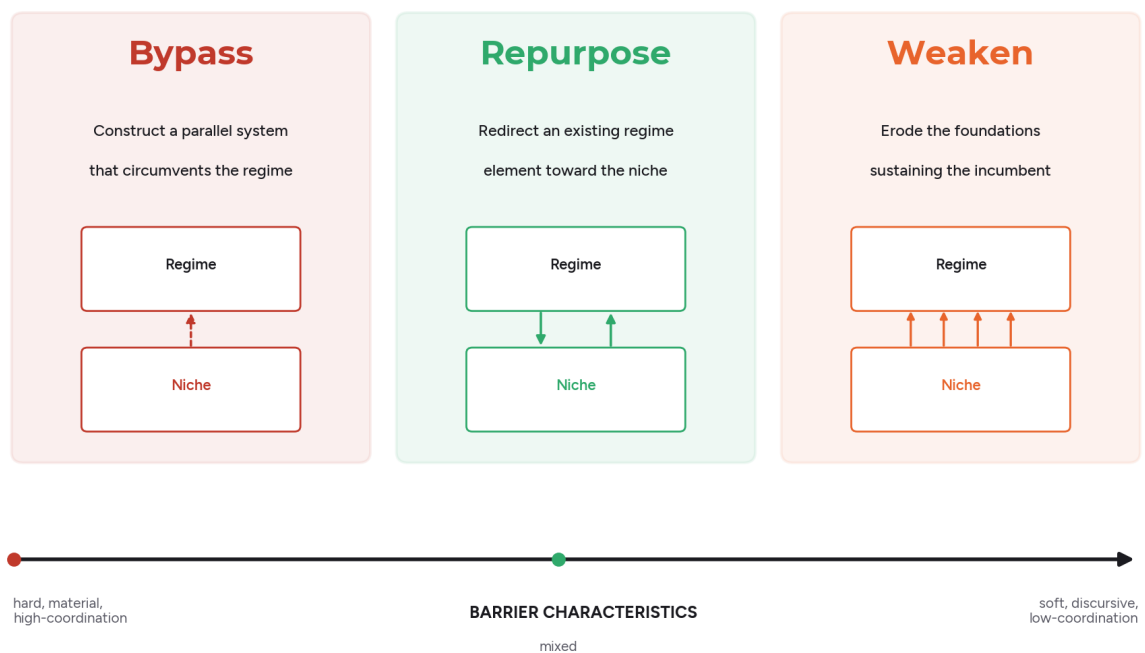


Figure 1. The BRW typology. Bypass constructs a parallel system that circumvents the regime; repurpose redirects an existing regime element toward the niche; weaken erodes the foundations sustaining the incumbent. The mechanisms are positioned along a barrier-characteristics spectrum running from hard, material, high-coordination constraints to soft, discursive, low-coordination ones.

MATCHING STRATEGIES TO BARRIERS

The barrier characterisation

A typology of strategies is only useful alongside a typology of the barriers they engage. The framework characterises each lock-in barrier along four dimensions, with a fifth regime-level modifier. Together they predict which mechanism is best matched to a given barrier.

Dimension	What it distinguishes
Materiality	Physical assets and infrastructure, versus cognitive frames, expectations, and meanings.
Tractability	Yields to short-horizon niche effort, versus requires long-horizon construction beyond the actor's control.
Coordination requirement	A single actor can resolve it, versus multiple actors must act together.
Coupling intensity	Bound to other barriers, so isolated resolution fails, versus independently addressable.
Regime coherence (modifier)	Actively defended by an aligned incumbent coalition, versus persisting through inertia and absence.

KEY POINT**The alignment proposition**

Bypass matches hard, high-materiality, high-coordination barriers. Weaken matches soft, low-materiality barriers. Repurpose occupies the intermediate ground where existing regime structure can be redirected. Misalignment between a strategy and the barrier it targets predicts observable failure modes.

- › In practice, the Lab characterises each barrier along all four dimensions from primary evidence, and weights regime coherence to context. The alignment above is the readable summary of a fuller analysis.

A WORKED EXAMPLE

BRW applied: electric motorcycles in Kenya

The framework was developed and illustrated through an embedded case study of Roam, an electric motorcycle manufacturer operating in Kenya's boda boda sector. Reading Roam's strategy portfolio through BRW substantiates the alignment proposition in its central tendency.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Roam in Kenya's boda boda regime

The regime. A mature petrol motorcycle-taxi ecosystem: fuel stations, roadside mechanics, informal financing, and stage-based rider communities, persisting in a porous, informal regime held together by ubiquity and habit rather than organised defence.

Bypass, matched to hard barriers. Battery-swap and charging networks, and pay-as-you-go financing over mobile money, build parallel systems against the hardest, most material, highest-coordination barriers (charging scarcity, capital exclusion).

Repurpose, matched to mixed barriers. Placing charging at existing retail sites, coordinating with the grid utility, and integrating with mobile money and rider SACCOs, redirect existing regime structure rather than rebuilding it.

Weaken, matched to soft barriers. Demonstrating lower running costs, correcting myths about reliability through word of mouth, and building electric-rider communities erode the incumbent's hold on soft, discursive barriers.

The pathway. Selective bypass in soft, low-materiality domains coexists with required construction in hard, high-materiality domains. The framework diagnoses this as bounded leapfrogging: not pure leapfrogging, not blocked, but bounded by which barriers can and cannot be circumvented.

The alignment held in its central tendency: bypass clustered against hard-material-high-coordination barriers, weaken against soft-low-materiality barriers, and repurpose in between where regime structure could be redirected. The informative outliers, a weaken mechanism reaching into hard economic territory where the cost advantage was already real, reveal the framework's internal structure rather than contradicting it.

WHY THIS IS A TRANSITIONS LAB FRAMEWORK

A mechanism-level diagnostic, from real fieldwork

BRW is not an armchair typology. It is developed deductively from the transitions and innovation-management literatures and illustrated through embedded fieldwork, and it is designed to travel across formal, informal, coherent, and porous regime configurations.

Its value to a partner is that it is comparative and mechanism-based. It turns a vague question, will this transition succeed?, into a precise one: is each strategy in the portfolio aligned with the barrier it targets, and where is it misaligned? A single project sees only its own sector; the Lab reads the same mechanisms across many, and can tell an innovator or funder which barriers they are actually engaging, whether their mix fits, and where they are most likely to stall.

The question is not how far a niche wants to change the regime. It is what each strategy actually does to each barrier in its way.

THE BRW FRAMEWORK

KEY POINT

How the Lab uses BRW in an engagement

We use BRW to frame a study before fieldwork begins: it tells us which barriers to characterise, which strategies to classify, and where to look for misalignment. It turns a broad brief into a precise diagnosis of strategy-barrier fit, and the fieldwork then confirms, refines, or overturns the initial reading.

WORKING WITH TRANSITIONS LAB

From framework to diagnosis

This resource sets out the BRW typology in full. Applying it to a live case, rigorously enough to guide a real decision, draws on further method the Lab brings to an engagement.

IN THIS FREE RESOURCE	IN AN ENGAGEMENT, WE GO FURTHER
The three mechanisms and the barrier characterisation, with a worked example.	› Formal coding of a full strategy portfolio against every barrier, not only the illustrative ones.
The four barrier dimensions and regime coherence, defined.	› Empirical characterisation of each barrier from primary fieldwork, rather than desk assessment.
The alignment proposition, in its central tendency.	› Systematic misalignment analysis, including the informative outliers that reveal where a strategy is quietly failing.
The Roam case, summarised.	› A comparable diagnosis of your own case, benchmarked against the Lab's cross-sector evidence base.

The framework is the lens; an engagement is where it is pointed at your evidence and read with the Lab's wider method behind it.

If a decision in your work turns on evidence of what a technology or programme actually does to real people, we are glad to talk it through, with no obligation. transitionslab.org

The BRW framework is developed in full in the academic work of Marcel Xing-Kai Kempers (TU Delft). This resource may be used and cited with attribution to Transitions Lab. transitionslab.org